

MEDALS OF THE MODERN ERA

The fragmentation of the colonial empires and the rise of new nations led to different forms of conflict, often without defined battles, but for which the combatants needed to be recognized. Some military operations, such as in Korea and Kosovo, involved forces acting on behalf of international organizations, rather than countries, who therefore issued medals. While the nature of war was changing, traditional acts of valour continued to provide the grounds for the award of many long-standing medals.



◀ LIAOHSI MEDAL

Date 1950

Origin China

Conflict Korean War

The distinctive bronze Liaohsi Medal for the Struggle to Resist the United States of America and Support Korea was issued to Chinese “volunteers” in the Korean War (1950–53). The enamelled front bears a map showing the Korean Peninsula and China.

▶ UN KOREA MEDAL

Date 1950

Origin UK/United Nations

Conflict Korean War

Different versions of the UN Korea Medal were awarded to forces from each participating nation, although all shared the same ribbon. The British medal (shown) was issued to British and Commonwealth forces who had served at least one full day in Korea.



◀ ORDER OF THE RED STAR

Date 1930

Origin Soviet Union



▲ ETHIOPIAN CONGO MEDAL

Date 1964

Origin Ethiopia

Conflict Congo Crisis

This medal was awarded to Ethiopians who served under the UN banner during the Congo Crisis of 1960–64. About 3,000 troops from the Imperial Bodyguard and part of an air squadron carried out peacekeeping duties.



▲ GENERAL SERVICE MEDAL

Date 1962

Origin UK

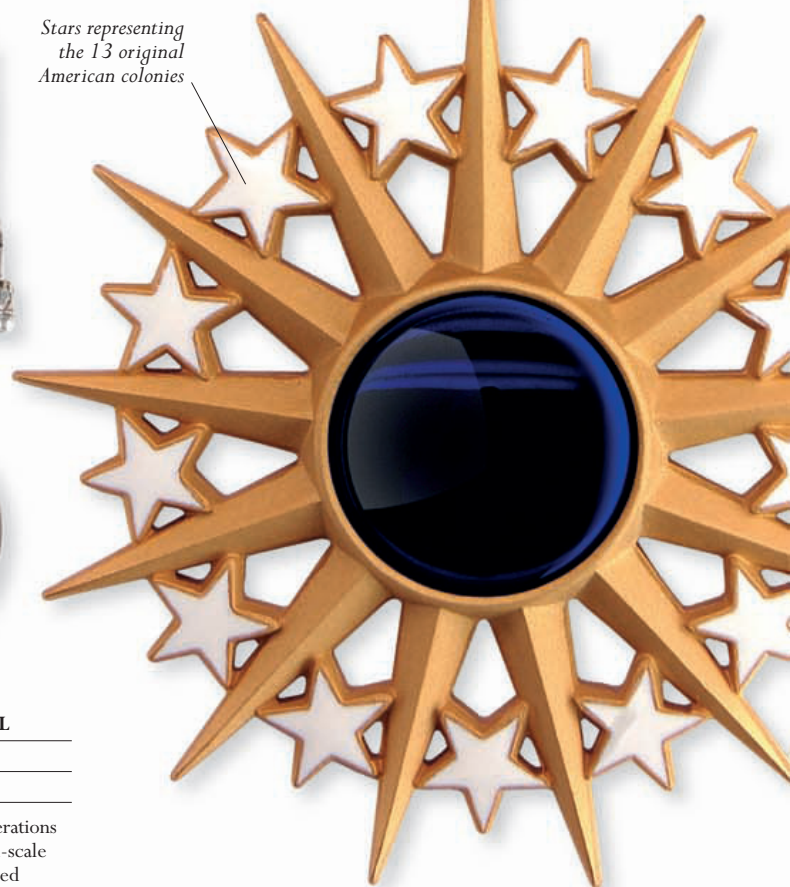
This award was made for minor operations and campaigns – those short of full-scale war. It was open to all the UK armed services. Thirteen clasps were awarded and 130,000 medals with the Northern Ireland clasp (shown) were issued (1969–2007).

The Red Star was awarded for achievements in the defence of the Soviet Union (both in war and peace) in the fields of state security, military science, weapons development, and courage and valour in battle. More than 4 million people received the order of the Red Star, with the last award made in 1991.



Medal suspended from stylized wings

Stars representing the 13 original American colonies



▲ AIR FORCE DISTINGUISHED SERVICE MEDAL

Date 1960

Origin US

This medal has a sunburst motif with a central blue stone representing the sky. Generally issued to high-ranking officers, it is awarded for “exceptionally meritorious service in a duty of unique and great responsibility”, in a combat or non-combat role.